

Space debris

An astronaut works on a spacecraft, and loses a tool. An ageing satellite begins to break up. A panel is knocked off a space station... space is littered with junk, and the problem is getting worse.

Cosmic litter

Examples of unexpected space rubbish include the following.



A **glove**, lost by an American astronaut on a spacewalk in 1965.



Rubbish bags, released by the *Mir* space station.



Two cameras, reported lost in space by astronauts.



Nuts and bolts, lost when satellites were being repaired.

Tracking the junk

An incredible amount of junk is orbiting the Earth. The path of anything larger than a tennis ball is tracked by scientists – currently more than 20,000 objects are being watched. Experts believe that, in total, well over half a million objects larger than 1 cm ($\frac{1}{2}$ in) are orbiting our planet.